

MENTAL HEALTH AND WELLNESS



Mental Health and Wellness

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Dear Annalia,

Look at you...so young and full of life despite everything. I wish I could just give you a big hug and let you know how unstoppable you are. You can truly do anything you want with your life. This life is yours and yours only. Do not let anyone tell you otherwise. I am writing to you because I know how hard things can be for you sometimes and I would like to provide some ways to alleviate your stressors and stay focused on how to give yourself the best life. I know there have been times where you felt like the world around you was collapsing, like a tornado ripping up everything good in your life. There have been times where you just want everything to stop and all you want is complete silence and stillness. Unfortunately that is not attainable but what you can do is find little ways to limit your hard times and change your mentality.

The first step in leading a greater life is to remove people, places, and ideas in your mind that no longer fit the life you wish to fulfill. Anyone who brings you down has got to go. People are going to try and nit pick even the smallest things about you; don't let them have that power. Let go of friendships that aren't 50/50. Hold onto those genuine people who fill you with joy and keep them close. Find a good support system and maintain those relationships with all your might. Let go of friends who just take and take without offering anything in return. Look for people who show they love you because anyone can just throw those words to you, but actions speak louder than words. Trust your instincts with this one. If it doesn't seem right then it probably isn't.

Leave and do not return to places that cause you more harm than pleasure. Not everywhere has to feel like home but there are only so many bad feelings one place can cause before turning sour. It's better to not let it get to that point and just listen to how you're feeling in certain places. Work spaces, school, homes of acquaintances, anywhere you go. Listen to how you're feeling.

Let go of ideas that don't allow you to be open and confident. This goes hand in hand with caring how others view you. You will live such a different life once you decide to care what you think about yourself and not let that be affected by outside opinions. You are truly the only one who has to live with yourself so you determine your worth. You determine what makes you a good or bad person; you decide to carry positive qualities or negative ones. You and you alone possess that power.

Another thing that could really help you out is trying to shift from a pessimistic view to a more optimistic one. Easier said than done I know but it is so important. In trying to accomplish a more positive mindset you are challenging yourself to be more open minded about possibilities. Specifically focusing on the efficacious outcomes rather than the negatives. Narrowing in on the positives keeps your mind forward-looking. Why be negative when you can be positive? You are making it harder on yourself, try not to let circumstances determine everything. Use the power of your mind; it is so much stronger than you think.

The biggest piece I have to mention is choosing to live. Get up everyday with an intention to feel alive. Do something with your day, even if it is small, anything that makes you happy or creative. It can be progressive, exciting, relaxing, just something to get a good emotion flowing. Get out of bed and into something beneficial. Move your body, whether that is dancing, yoga, gym, swimming, or even something smaller like stretching. You are the only one who can make your life worth living; this can definitely be a hard achievement but start small. It's all you can do. When you get older it is going to feel like everything is speeding up; before you can even catch your breath, this ride we call life will be coming to a stop. Take it all in and live to the fullest. I have to mention there are many things you are already doing to improve your mental quality. Listening to music is a big one. Using music to feel and work through your own emotions is such a powerful tool. You are pretty intune with your body and emotions but there is always room for improvement. Spending time and being a friend to yourself can boost how harmonious you are within.

These are just a few things that can truly help better your peace of mind. None of these are a one and done type of situation either. Maintaining a peaceful headspace and surrounding atmosphere takes work and constant keep up. Just be attentive. It is a lot of work but I know you can do it; it will be so worth it in the end. There's only so much you have to actually go through, the rest is just extra we throw onto ourselves. It doesn't have to be that way. Keep going please and be as clear minded as possible. Have fun and live your life to your fullest capabilities. Help yourself out; life doesn't have to be so hard all the time.

Love you

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Dear Ash,

Please know that I write this with blood on my pen. I was 8 when I was red in the face for a boy and 9 when I realized I couldn't trust him because I was terrified he might turn out like dad. I don't remember you much from elementary years, only fragments of when I was in a new state again and I couldn't figure out why I was afraid of a room full of people. 13 when I finally figured out why.

I couldn't stand looking in the mirror, afraid I'd see their words written in my reflection as if they're not already engraved in my mind. I blamed you for being unable to speak up, for cowering away, for being afraid. So I played with fire so often that I started building a house of ice. A sublime change occurred then and I'm not talking about the color of my hair. I became someone I do not recognize. The girl I used to be was crushed by the woman I am now.

I was in high school when I started realizing you and I were no longer one. A painful process, our flesh ripping at the seams and I couldn't feel anything anymore, not even the sweet resonate of an ache. I became cruel. I resented you, the little girl with pink ribbons in her hair. I did not move freely anymore, rather I had delicate threads kneaded into my skin, roughly pulling me away from you. I used to cry out in pain each time. Cries turned into screams turned unto whimpers and are now nothing but soft whispers in my head. I was in a constant battle with you, people around me no longer wore faces. That's how I lived from then on. A blade lodged in my heart each time someone tried to get close to me.

I was 18 in a different state when I started licking my wounds. I began missing you. I didn't want the last memories of us to be tainted with the malicious colors of my pride. I reminisced about the beautiful memories of who I used to be, but they are starting to decay at the corners. I am 20 now, and I am still feeling the ripples of what was done to me years ago. Don't get

me wrong, I still laugh and I indulge as if the color of my mistakes isn't staining the future. I ignore my hands trembling as I try to reach out to you. I'll find you again, little Ash. I'll find you in the swirling summer air, in the sound of rushing cars, in the crevices of my scars, I promise I'll get to you one day.

Until then,

Ashley

- Mental Health has been on a decline and has been called a "silent epidemic" since.
- In 2021, 60% of college students suffered from mental health issues.
- There has been a 40% increase in students seeking help and is still increasing since the pandemic.
- Since there was a spike in caseloads, there is no funding to cover it.

Work Cited:

Abrams, Zara. "Student Mental Health Is in Crisis. Campuses Are Rethinking Their Approach." *Monitor on Psychology*, American Psychological Association, 1 Oct. 2022, <https://www.apa.org/monitor/2022/10/mental-health-campus-care>).

Author's Note:

I want other people to be able to express themselves through short letters like these. As I mentioned previously, mental health is an extremely personal topic for me and I wish I can do more to help others.

My initial purpose for this letter is to inspire others to do the same and learn from their past. My goal is to acknowledge what has happened because it is a great way to start the journey of self-healing and inner peace.

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Dear Sommer,

I hope this letter finds you well. So many things have happened to you in the life you have lived. I would like you to know that you were never alone and that many of people have experienced the depression you have experienced. I would like for you to know that we found a way to wake up in the morning even when we didn't want to, we figured out that eating more than a meal a day is more beneficial than not, and we found out ways to cope with these feelings positively instead of acting on negative impulses. Most importantly, we figured out that there is more to life than feeling like we were almost stuck in this life with no way out.

What was hard to us in the beginning was not knowing what was so different about our brain. I like to think it all started for us when our parents got divorced. I remember how it felt when we would see them arguing and how it was confusing seeing them the next day cuddling on the couch. I also think that's what I thought love was, arguing horrendously and then acting as if nothing happened. What we later found out is that this is toxicity and not healthy. After this it all seemed to go downhill. Once our mother found a new husband, we were left to fend for ourselves because she didn't seem to care anymore. This made us independent at a very young age. There would be days when all we ate were 99 cent store whale crackers, we were only 13.

Once we got into high school, we tried to be better. We got into cross country, soccer, track and tried to get better grades than we did in middle school. Who would've known that high school would be worse than middle school. The only interaction with our mom we ever had was horrific arguing. Our father was a control freak and a master manipulator; no where we would go ever felt safe. We looked up to our best friend's mother as our own mother because even they knew your home life wasn't great. At 15 and 16 years old we were never home. Although our father had some negative traits, he was the only parent who would provide for you.

When we turned 17 you know everything changed. Our father left and moved to a different state for a job leaving you with just your mother. I know he was reluctant to leave you here in Tucson and begged you to move with him but starting over in another state sounded scarier than living with your mother, so you stayed. At this point in our lives our mother let us do whatever we wanted and just stopped caring all together. This is when we were introduced to drugs and a boy who would leave

you with emptiness and relationship PTSD. From 17 to 19 years old life was all about going through the motions. We started failing school, failing college, failed friendships, and failing overall as a person. We didn't know how far in life we were going to make it.

Finally, after all the hardships in life, we decided to finally turn ourselves around. We started making healthier choices and not acting on impulse, for example instead of turning to drugs when something triggering happens, we talk about what is bothering us. We got rid of the people who were in our lives that had a negative impact on us. We got our first apartment after being in plenty of homes that never really felt like homes, we met a man who we are in love with and we just celebrated our two years together, we now have two cats finally after begging for that companionship since I was 8 years old, and we finally have a stable job and are excelling in college. Look at us! Who would've thought.

The main reason why I am writing this to you, is to tell you I am so proud of YOU. You wanted better for yourself, and I am so happy you put in the effort and admitted you needed help when you did. I know admitting you needed help was the toughest thing you ever had to do, but I'm glad you did because I am not sure if we would even be here now if you didn't. This is all we ever wanted for ourselves, is to feel ok. Never forget how you got here, by going to therapy, by working through our issues, by realizing and understanding what we are going through, by forgiving by never forgetting, and by knowing that there is so much more to life than depression and mental illness. If we had never used these tools; life could have very well ended, if not that you would be here today stuck in the same cycle. YOU are more than your illness. If we can help others who are going through what we are with the same tools you used to help you get through this, then it's a life worth living. I am glad we never gave up, and I want you to share your story, even if it only helps one person. You are strong, you are in control of YOUR life, and most of all, you deserve to be happy regardless of the circumstances you have been given.

Be easy on yourself. Continue to do great things.

With so much love,

Yourself, Sommer Quezada

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Dear Steph,

I remember senior year when you stopped going to school, when you quit your job, and stopped talking to us. I remember the days you would come to school, you left early because you weren't feeling good, or when you would sit in your car instead of going to class. No one took these changes into consideration.

I'm sorry that it took us so long to notice that you weren't okay, that we didn't put everything together sooner. I'm sorry you had to lose nearly everything for us to notice. There was no help provided for you, no counselors, no family, or friends. You were on your own for nearly 6 months, and your attempt was what made everyone finally notice.

Being emotionally unavailable wasn't something we saw a lot or were aware about, it's not that we didn't want to help you it's just we didn't know the signs. We all figured it was just "senioritis." I'm sorry that while you were at home contemplating everything, we were at senior ditch days, or we were eating at your favorite restaurants.

I now realize how many of us are affected, we seem to brush everything off. Brushing everything off will never help us get out of this stage. We can all help each other; we can come together and make it known that not being okay is okay. That seeking help is okay and so is needing each other. So many have been on the same boat as you, and no help has ever been provided.

You were so afraid to be seen as "weak" for having the mindset you did. Mental health is no joke. When we express it, we are seen as vulnerable. Nobody is taught enough. How should we know that staying in bed all day was a sign? Or being tired all the time is also a sign? We have regulated everything that we

have no idea what to look for. Everyone also jokes about "im gonna kms" but how are we supposed to know that they're being serious when it's being said all the time.

Our generation seems to be seen as "weak" since many seek the help they need while older generations always portray themselves as stronger, as if they were never had a weak mind. They compare themselves to our generation because when have we ever seen them at therapist appointments or when have we ever seen them in physic wards, majority of our parents taught us to keep our feelings to ourselves, but we are slowly undoing what they have taught us.

You're much stronger than who your parents are. You're much stronger than your traumas growing up. Accepting that you're not okay is the biggest step through the process. Thank you for making me realize that this is all okay, for making me aware of all the signs and what I could do to help. If it weren't for you I would be clueless of what mental health is. Thank you Steph, not only for helping me but for staying here and trying your best. We're all very proud of you for working to get everything you lost back, were proud of you for getting yourself back. I'm proud of you for going back to school, for getting your own business, going to therapy, and being able express yourself. Thank you for everything.

Stay safe and well,

Leslie Loera

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Dear younger self,

I want to start off by saying I'm proud of you. Your 20's were rough, and you had to face many challenges. During these challenges you were faced with a lot of depression, and still until this day you struggle with anxiety. Depression runs in your family. You will see your mom and your sister go through rough times. All three of you will seek help and will be put on medication and that is ok! Events that happen in your life will put you in a dark place. The best way to describe it is like you're in quicksand and can't get out of it. But you end up coming out of that dark place. Through medication and counseling you were able to beat depression. I want to say that I am proud of you for seeking help and realizing that mental illness is a serious medical condition that cannot be overlooked, but please do not give up.

I know at times it seems so far from your reach and that it may feel like you are going to feel depressed and anxious forever, but you will overcome it. Mental illness is an everyday battle; it's not something that goes away from one day to the next. Mental illness runs in your family. Mental health will be talked about more as you get older. The anxiety seems to never really go away it's a challenge you will be faced with every day. The more that you are open about your mental health and the struggles you face other people will come forth and talk to you about their struggles as well. This makes it easier to know that you are not alone.

You'll go through your 20's learning a lot about yourself. When you hit your 30's you will feel like you can conquer anything.

You will have your first baby. Something you've been wanting for so long. You will experience postpartum depression. That's a type of depression I don't think you were prepared for. People will tell you "You just had a baby how could you be so sad?" Its really something you can't control and that will be the biggest hurdle you will have to jump. Post- partum depression is hard to deal with because you just had a baby, you feel alone, your body just went through so many changes, and you become extremely anxious. A first-time mom and suddenly you are faced with so many challenges that you were not prepared for. This is going to be the hardest most rewarding time in your life. Thank goodness you have the best support system in the world. This depression and anxiety that you feel will soon turn into bliss and happiness. Just be patient with yourself and live in the moment.

So, I say this to you my younger self. Be gentle with yourself don't be so hard on yourself and don't worry through all the pain, anxiety, and hurt. You will flourish. You will learn to love yourself so much. With all the resources out there and all the love and support that you receive you will come out of your depression. Here are my words of advice to you. Surround yourself with family and friends, exercise, go to counseling, learn to love yourself, and learn to accept what you are going through. You are not alone. I am so proud of you.

Love,

your older self

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Dear younger self,

Hey, how are you feeling? From what I remember not too well huh? I wish I could tell your life is great and you have become so happy. Do not give up, you do find different kinds of happiness. I do not remember when we started feeling like this. I remember all our days spent in bed, not eating, watching the same movie repeatedly. We would spend hours feeling the water of the shower head hit our body. Feeling so empty and lonely, wanting someone by our side so badly but too afraid to tell anyone. The feeling that anything we did was a huge task, took all our energy to get out of bed. I wish you did not have to go through this alone.

During this difficult time our grandmother just died and that hit us extremely hard. I remember feeling sad beforehand, but I do believe that it pushed us over the edge. Covid started a couple months after we started having these intense emotions of sadness. When covid started, it was comforting to have an excuse to stay home and not see people. Laying in the house sounded like the only option we had. I could not have imagined leaving the house. Laughing, smiling, and making conversation sounded like a nightmare. We were relieved not to go to school or get out of bed. Our mom worked overnight so we were all alone at night and during the day while she slept. I understand that is what she had to do to support us, however it left us feeling completely alone at the house. Now, our depression was not her fault or our grandmothers passing, it just made everything feel lonely.

I am happy to tell you that it does get easier. Do not give up on yourself, you will come a long way. This life is crazy and messy, but it can be beautiful. There will always be ups and downs in your life. Try to focus on the ups and don't let the downs eat you up. There are going to be more challenges that you will face. More people will walk out of your life, and it will feel lonely. You need to focus on the person that does come into your life, show them so much love. Both them and you do not know how much you guys will help each other. You will start

going to the gym and that will help your mind. Going on car rides feels peaceful when your mind feels like it is suffocating.

I want to leave you with some things that helped us get to the place we are at. I know we are not perfect now and probably will never be. You will find out that no one is. We start making it a point to get out of bed every morning. It is important for us to start our morning off with getting up. If we do not, then we will not get out of bed that day. I mentioned the gym and going on drives helps us clear our mind. It does, cleaning oddly does too. I wish I could tell you what changed in our mind to jump start our way back out. It gradually got better for us, there are days where we are knocked back down. We still have days where all we want to do is lay in bed and do not feel like putting on a smile. The good will always way out the bad.

There are people to help you that you do not even notice. School is not our favorite place, it does get better, but the counselors do have resources. I know we are scared to go to them, and we did not. However, it probably would have been useful for us. Knowing your options gives you more peace of mind. The job we have now even helps with therapy. You feel that you will not make it and that your life won't turn out good. I am here to tell you hold on; our life gets easier. You will have a stable home and people that care for you. You are not alone in this world. Life won't always be like this, life is rewarding. Everyone says that you are so young and so much life to live. Knowing us we probably would just roll our eyes at them, but it is true we have so much life to live. I wish you could love yourself the way you love other people. You know how it feels to be at your lowest and you never know when somebody is at theirs. Be kind to yourself and to others.

Keep your head up,

Your future self

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This Instagram covers specific and practical approaches to health and well-being. You can view it here, https://www.instagram.com/global_health_project/.

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Have you ever wondered what would happen if you didn't go outside often? Or if being inside all day affects your mental health? As a person who doesn't go outside often, I can say these questions have been rambling around in my mind. I never thought much about going outside until I read about a boy who gave up everything to live in the woods for two years. Yeah, I know! Crazy!

At first, I thought, "I would never go live in the woods and give up everything I have." I have come to reconsider my thoughts. No, I still wouldn't give up all my belongings and shelter to live in the woods, but why would someone want to do such a thing? I began to research. "Is not going outside bad for you?" and "What would happen if humans never went outside?" Well, it cannot be suitable for us to stay inside all the time!

Studies show that some effects of not going outside include anxiety and depression. "Anxiety and depression, both of those things go up when you're stuck inside. Even if you're choosing to be stuck inside" (Dabney as qtd. By Taylor). Us humans need shelter, but we also need exposure to sunlight. We are supposed to go outside.

According to the director of the Sleep and Chronobiology Laboratory at the University of Colorado, Boulder, Kenneth Wright, "exposure to sun-strength rays helps calibrate your body's circadian "clock" (as ctd. By Heid). "Your circadian rhythm regulates everything from appetite and sleep schedules to mood and energy levels" (Wright as qtd. By Heid). That is a lot of things! Electric lighting, such as phones, computers, TVs, and lights in our houses, is not the best for humans. "An absence of natural light can throw off your sleep schedule leading to increased risk of obesity, diabetes, depression, and other diseases" (Wright as qtd. By Heid). Richard Ryan, a professor of psychology, says, "Green nature" in particular—forests and parks, as opposed to beaches or deserts—seems to provide the most benefit" (as qtd. by Heid). Nature is known to improve your mood and mental health. Getting outside also helps us stay more active. "We tend to be less active indoors. When we're outside, we're more likely to walk and use our muscles, even if it's just walking to the grocery store" (Shah as qtd. by Taylor). Spending time in nature seems to relax people. It clears your mind's workload. Sadly, our generation is so attached to our phones, computers, and TVs. It prevents people from getting outside as much as they did when they were kids.

Summer is one of my favorite seasons! In the summer, people typically go outside more than they do any other time of the year. Most families will go on vacation somewhere, but if not, they stay home and spend more time at the pool or a lake. I have noticed that in the summer, I am much calmer and more relaxed. I wonder, is it because I am getting so much sun exposure? I'm starting to think it is! I get a lot more vitamin D in the summer

than in winter. I have less anxiety, my stress levels are low, and mentally I am happier. I can also sleep better. Some people say, "the sun drains me." I can relate to that! After a long day in the sun, I know I will sleep like a baby!

While enjoying the benefits of outside time in the summer, be sure to protect yourself with sunscreen and hydration. The cool thing is that even if we wear clothes and sunscreen, we still get plenty of sunshine and vitamin D.

One of the best times of the year is autumn. The air is fresh and crisp. It is the perfect temperature for a lovely evening walk or bike ride. I love autumn because it is still pretty warm, but there is a cool breeze. Unfortunately, last fall, I did not get outside very often. I am going to try and change that this year. Although I live in the burning heat of Arizona, anytime it is colder out, it's refreshing!

Since it is so hot in Arizona, sometimes I don't even want to leave my house! "You miss a lot when you surround yourself with walls, and sunlight tops the list" (Wright as ctd. by Heid).

I plan to do something outside when I get a day off from work. Doing something outside helps me refresh my mind and get some sun. Recently I have tried to go on a walk or a hike at least once a week. Everyone can struggle with getting outside, especially with a demanding school and work schedule. Even one day a week of ensuring I get outside significantly impacts me. I get very stressed out and have anxiety about minor things. By making an effort to go out more, I have been more relaxed and not as tense. Going out and doing something outside will become a part of my weekly schedule.

An issue that I have identified today is that people do not go outside as much as they used to. Remember when you were young and played all the time outdoors? Kids love going outside. When I was little, I would wake up and want to go to the park. In the summer, I wanted to swim all day. In the Fall, I wanted to go to the park outside and run around with my friends. In the winter, I wanted to sit by the fire with a blanket and drink hot cocoa. In the spring, I wanted to sit on a bench and color pages in my coloring book. Yes, people still do these things, but I know I don't do them as much as I used to. In elementary school, everyone has a recess. As we get older and start high school, typically, you only get outside if you play a sport that practices outside. People don't realize the impact that this has on many people in our world. Most kids don't have bad mental health or depression.

Mental health is one of the most popular topics in today's society. Why? Because it affects so many people. Every individual has struggles. Some are worse than others. If getting outside has so many benefits, why wouldn't we try and make a better effort to spend more time outdoors? Being in the sun could help those who struggle with anxiety, high stress,

depression, insomnia, etc. The only solution to fix this is getting outside. Even just 20-45 minutes a day will be so beneficial.

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Hello my friend,

First off, I just wanted to see how you have been recently. I know that you don't have the best support around you, but you have people here for you. I want to let you know that you matter, and nothing can change that. I can't say that I have dealt with what you have gone through, but I'm here for you if you need anything. Even if you just need someone to vent to, I can be that person. You will never be a burden to me no matter the circumstances. No matter what happens, I believe you. I know others say this is for attention, but I know that is not true. It can be hard sometimes when it feels like nobody is listening to you, so I want to reiterate that I am here for you at any time.

Mental health issues are a growing problem today and must be taken more seriously. Just because it is an issue that cannot physically be seen does not mean that it is not urgent. The statistics back this up. 1 in 5 adults in the U.S have experienced mental health issues. While this statistic may show that mental health issues have been getting worse over the years, I view this as a good thing because more people are being diagnosed. Many years ago, there were probably people with mental health issues, but because society deemed it as taboo, many people refused to get diagnosed. This is why I view it as a good thing because people are recognizing they have an issue and trying to fix it.

A problematic mental space is an issue in itself, but it could also lead to other issues. I'm not saying that it will be easy, in fact, it will be difficult. You will have to make some decisions that others do not necessarily agree with, but you need to focus on what will help you. Unfortunately, some relationships may

deteriorate, but those people are not your true friends. You have had to start this journey on healing by yourself with no support and I don't think I could do that with a smile on my face like you have.

Many people are affected by mental health issues whether it is someone they know or themselves, so it is not just a trend that will go away. There are many different ways to help combat this. One way is to focus on your physical health. I know that there are times when I have felt down and when I start to improve my physical health, my mental health also improves. It doesn't have to be much, but just something to take your mind off of things for a bit. Another strategy is to talk to a professional. I know sometimes it is looked down upon as if you are weak for doing this, but I think this is a sign of a strong person. You recognize that something is off, so you go talk to someone that knows how to deal with it. As much as I can help, I am not a professional in this subject. If you need to seek professional help, I will gladly help you find someone.

I will keep you in my thoughts and want you to know that I am there for you as well as many others. You are not alone.

Sincerely,

Your friend Joshua

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Metabolic health can be overlooked by many people in the world, especially in the West. Obesity is not only bad for your health in general, for example, but you might also have an increased chance of diabetes and various cardiovascular diseases. However, I believe there is a silent killer that can be overlooked. I believe that for some people, metabolic health is correlated to mental health.

When you are obese or overweight, I think naturally you lose self-esteem. This would be obvious for some people, however, I believe that when you consume a bad diet, for some people it negatively impacts your mental health, such as having anxiety or depression. Anecdotally, I have seen people and myself with prominent conditions, which I will not name for personal reasons. Moreover, I also believe that it is vague on what is healthy and what is not. I find it odd that people and society will demonize fats when it is important for us to have and live because it is one of the building blocks of our body, but they will promote an excessive amount of carbs. Obesity in America, to me, is very common, and obviously fat free foods are not helping at all.

Furthermore, what I have seen in my own experience, is that an excessive amount of sugar or carbs does not sit well with some people. Many people do not know this, but in your abdominal region which covers your stomach, is a nerve called the vagus nerve. This nerve connects to your stomach and goes to the central nervous system and into the brain. This is important

because if your stomach or body does not respond well to certain foods hypothetically speaking, then it might cause some repercussions such as conditions like anxiety or depression.

Furthermore, I earlier stated that it was with some people. I believe that in general there should be more research on added sugars and man-made fats, which most likely impacts anyone negatively, however, I believe for certain, that some people do not respond to sugar or carbs well and it might be one of the reasons for your condition. For example, it is like a person who is lactose intolerant. He cannot drink milk because he does not have the necessary enzyme to break it down. So, like sugar, when people eat sugar or carbs it results in those conditions.

Lastly, I would recommend with people who have an uncontrollable condition, to try to eat low carbs and make protein and maybe fat your priority to see if it helps you. I can say it has helped me tremendously, however, I also do not think that this condition is solely just metabolic health as I think it is a combination of different things that accumulate and lead to the same results. For example, having low vitamin d. Hoped this helped and would also recommend everyone try a low-carb diet to see if it makes you feel better.

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Dear younger self,

It is now September 2022. I have taken some time to reflect on the events that we have been through together and I have since realized a few things. You are 18 now; by this time you already have met someone who you *thought* was going to be around for a while. And, while you are sort of right about that, the relationship doesn't last as long as you think. For some people 3 years is not a long time, but it is when you lose yourself within those years. I am sickened by what I let slide, and sickened by knowing I was a doormat to someone who I thought loved me. You must be confused at this part of the letter, and you will be until he finally shows his true colors, and it won't take long.

My one message to you, if anything, is to not let him or anyone else control you because they don't know how to control their emotions/feelings. The arguments that turned into lies and betrayal, name calling, purposeful disrespect, you deserved none of it. Nothing you can do is ever worth that type of reaction from someone, especially when that person claims to love you. I also want to let you know, that I do forgive you. You let a lot happen to you that you knew were not right, and you stayed for the sake of trying to fix that person, and that is not a way for you or anyone to live.. it isn't living.

It's hard knowing now that you will hit rock bottom and there will be absolutely nothing left for you, within this relationship. It will take you spiraling and not being able to recognize yourself anymore, to realize this is not how you want your life to continue. Another thing to keep in mind is that jealousy is the worst trait anyone can ever have. I'm sure you have fresh arguments that have stemmed from jealousy on your partner's part, and know that again, it is not your fault. Some men choose to internalize their issues, and it comes out as disrespect to those they hold close, and overall ruins relationships with

family/friends. I realize you probably don't understand this concept because you think the issue is just you, but look at how he treats his mother... She didn't deserve any of those hateful words/actions either.

Parents are partly to blame when their sons are not capable of treating women/people with respect. In your partners case his dad was not around, his mom is an active alcoholic, and a lot of things that wouldn't be allowed in your home, were allowed in this place that you called your second home. I know you enjoy the freedom you feel when you come to this home, but you will realize that structure is important. If your partner had more structure growing up, was taught how to communicate effectively, and overall just learned emotional maturity you might've been golden. The connection will always be there, but the treatment you received was and will never be okay.

Don't be afraid to leave this chapter behind us, there is better coming and I know that it may not seem this way now, but you will love yourself in the future for it. I am here to tell you that you will find someone that does not see you as a burden and treats you with the amount of respect you give and deserve. It is possible to find a man who is not jealous of every little thing you do, you just have to allow yourself to accept the good coming, and DO NOT overlook those red flags because I know you see them. Anyway, I hope this letter finds you well and gives you the strength to know that your life isn't over because of this failed relationship, and you will eventually heal. I love you!

Love,

The older me.

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My Boys,

I cannot express the love I have for you enough. To watch you all grow individually into your own personalities makes me smile. I'm writing this to you to better explain an issue I not only struggle with, but many moms do, and I'll try my best. There's an inner illness a lot of people struggle with and sometimes it is hard to see, but doesn't mean it's not there, and it's called depression. It means that someone is very sad, or they are not motivated to do the things they enjoy anymore.

This doesn't mean I love you boys or love spending time with you any less, it means I feel I must work harder at staying happy. It is a constant battle in my own head and heart to be genuinely happy majority of the time. When I was 15, I started the war I continue now with depression and anxiety. It quickly turned into postpartum depression when Julian was born. That does not make it your fault at all, it is an unfortunate event that about 600,000 women per year get after having a baby. This type of depression is very hormonal based rather than chemical and can eventually go away. When the twins came along, I went through it again, which was not easy and as someone who already had depression this was something I knew I could and still can overcome. The great thing is that there are medications that can help ease depression and help increase this chemical in your brain, called serotonin, which helps uplift your mood and suppress the depression or anxiety.

This illness is something that can be passed on, if it is something common with family, it can happen to you too. That does not mean any of you will feel this way as well, but it means if you do, don't let it bring you down. Always understand there are resources, not just medication but professionals to talk to. Remembering that you are not alone and that the many

people suffering from the same issues are feeling almost the same way you are. It's a problem some more than others, must face in our world, but there are so many options to help overcome it.

There are so many avenues to take to overcoming these dark thoughts or alone feelings. I'm not sure what you will grow up to be interested in quite yet but if I were to guess now, for you Julian, helping you out of a depression would be to read a book, play with your little brothers, or cuddle. Roman, I can only imagine you'll have an interest in anything that is loud since you are the loudest little screecher we have in the house. As for you Atti, it would probably be just hanging out with your mom or dad that would make you feel better. What helps me is to either take a bath, nap, or watch funny movies. These are huge things that help my mind stop dwelling in the bad, and take it to a nicer, calmer place to relax me.

I work hard every day at making sure I can be the best and most loving mother to you three. Not every day is a success story, but nothing brings me more joy than seeing you, Julian, Roman, and Atticus grow into the amazing men you'll be one day. If you find yourselves falling into the same dark minded state I have, just know you are not alone and I will always be here to guide you and help you back to your motivation in life. I love you boys with every fiber in my body, and depression could never change that.

Love,

Mom

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Women's health care is considered a joke to a lot of women because of the way their complaints and symptoms are ignored. Most women have had a bad experience first hand or know someone who has. Women's complaints are often taken very lightly when it comes to health care. If we state we are in pain and are not screaming and crying we are not believed; however, if we are screaming and crying we are being dramatic. I personally have spent 18 hours in the ER only to find out I actually had an ectopic pregnancy and my fallopian tube had ruptured.

That day another hospital had been shut down and there was an overload of people in the ER. People were being brought in on gurneys from ambulances and were left in the hallways. I had been waiting for hours in the back area trying to sit on a chair, but I could not sit directly on my rear because of the intense pain and pressure. I wasn't talking much because I was using all my energy to handle the pain.

I noticed that other people in beds and in gurneys seemed to be somewhat comfortable and some even laughing. No one seemed to be in excruciating pain like I was. I saw that someone had asked for a bed and they were given one. I finally gathered enough strength to get up and ask a nurse for a bed. I was hunched over and my face was clammy. I was denied a bed so I asked for a pillow. The nurse looked at me like I was a junky. I don't remember who or when, but sometime after this I ended up getting a wheelchair. I was in incredible pain for hours and hours. I was 20 years-old and was just following ER protocol; patiently waiting my turn.

I kept feeling an urge to use the restroom. I tried to wheel myself to the restroom. The bathroom was of course occupied. There was a trash can outside the bathroom and I asked someone to hand it to me. I threw up. A nurse saw me and quickly got me a gurney and some morphine. She instantly saw that I needed help immediately. She yelled at some people to get me what I needed, and it wasn't long before I was actually seen.

They had me take a urine test, which was very difficult for me. I could hardly walk and I kept feeling this pressure like I needed to use the restroom, but I couldn't. They took my blood pressure and it was very low and they seemed highly concerned. I finally heard someone say from another room, "She's pregnant!!!" At this point I was thinking I was really pregnant like it was a viable pregnancy. They took me to get a sonogram. I saw the "baby." It looked like a starfish. Its limbs were spread out and there were no hands or feet. They quickly turned the screen. I was young and I was still thinking this was a viable pregnancy. No one had told me anything. I was just going off of what I overheard and accidentally saw. Well, the doctor came back and finally told me what happened. I had to sign paperwork right away to get emergency surgery.

I was told if I waited any longer to come to the hospital I would have died. That "pressure" I kept feeling, like I needed to pee, was actually me bleeding internally. I had about a baseball's size of blood inside my body from the rupture.

If they would have taken me seriously to begin with I could have been treated sooner. Maybe if they would have given a urine test sooner...

About a year later I was pregnant again. I started bleeding at 12 weeks. I went to the hospital. They did a doppler to hear the heartbeat. There was no heartbeat. The doctor said, "Well, there is no heartbeat so you know what that means." I did not know what that meant. I was given paperwork that said "miscarriage" on it. I was not given a sonogram or anything. I was told it would pass on its own. It did not pass on its own. A couple of weeks later I started having cramps (now I know it was more like contractions). I was bleeding very heavily and ended up taking an ambulance because of how heavy the bleeding was. I needed to get a D&C because my body was not passing the fetus or embryo (I still don't know how far along I was before it stopped growing). For those of you who do not know what a D&C is, it is very invasive. They literally go inside of you and suck the fetus out. Medication is a much better option as it lets your body naturally release the fetus, but it was never given to me as an option.

I feel like the first doctor could have actually treated me. He could have ordered an ultrasound to see how far along the fetus was and to see how long it had been since it stopped growing. He could have treated me for a missed-miscarriage instead of sending me on my way. And definitely better bedside manners.

Fast forward to a little over a decade later. I was pregnant again, about six weeks. I started bleeding and went to the hospital. There was no heartbeat and it measured at 5 weeks. It was another possible missed-miscarriage, but they could not be certain so I would have to follow-up with a sonogram a week later. I went and paid \$150 out-of-pocket for the follow-up sonogram. Still measuring 5 weeks and no heartbeat. So I can get treated for missed-miscarriage now right? Nope! I had to follow-up again another week. I did this for 4 weeks and it was the same each time. No growth. No heartbeat. \$150 each time. I was a struggling single mother at that time and the costs were killing me. I had been cramping on and off the entire month while starting a new job. I just wanted to get on with my life. I wanted to feel normal again. I finally was able to get treatment for the missed-miscarriage, which was what people call "the abortion pill". I was happy I was finally going to get treatment. I planned it so I can get the medication on my day off because I knew it was going to be very painful and a long process to pass the unviable embryo. I went to the pharmacy and I was embarrassed because the pharmacist denied my prescription because of his beliefs. I tried to explain my situation while other

customers were waiting behind me, but they would not give me my prescription. It was embarrassing and I was in tears. I waited a whole month to finally get treatment and this man would not give me the medication I needed. I ended up going to another pharmacy and finally was given my medication. Everyone was so scared to treat me because they didn't want to be part of an "abortion."

These are just a couple of my experiences with women's healthcare. There are so many more stories out there. We are not taken seriously when it comes to our complaints and we are not given appropriate treatment because of it.

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They sit at a table with a hollowed and empty chair
Each heart wishing they still had the one who used to sit there
The house feels so empty without the sound of her laughter
No way they knew that something like this would happen after
There is nothing that could replace her presence for them all
Never to be the same, and no one to answer that call
She took her own life at only seventeen years of age
The book of her life would never turn to another page

-Please do not take your life-

Picture for a moment a scene that you might know
In our own city with the heartache it might show
A school gym and a stadium full of mourners
Of grief-stricken parents standing in the corners
The principal addressing the agonized crowd
The silence more deafening than anything loud
They all had just seen her kindly face yesterday
None could ever believe that she would go away
Hundreds of people grieving a single passing
If only the hopeless could see them all massing

-Please do not take your life-

And I know it's a hard topic to bring up in public these days
An uncomfortable subject as your sudden squirming betrays
But it is happening far too much for us to simply not care
We cannot ignore the plight of human suffering found out there
And I know that some people feel like there's no hope for their futures

In a world with so many wounds unhealed by balms or by sutures

They see all the good things come crashing down in a sorrowful end

And they feel like they cannot go on without breaking from that bend

-Please do not take your life-

I apologize if I sound overly dramatic

But I simply refuse to ignore something this tragic

These broken souls need someone who's trying to bring them aid

This cost of depression is a price too many have paid

There are so many who are drowning in worlds without hope

Seeing such a bleak future, how can any of them cope?

If we have a chance to tell these youth how precious they are,

Would we attempt to step out of our comfort zone that far?

We must do something, anything, and not sit idly by

In the midst of a generation that's wondering why

They should even be trying to get up out of their beds

I assure you that this issue isn't just in our heads

-Please do not take your life-

We are facing a health crisis in the U.S.

Of adults dealing with heavy mental distress

We see it in the year 2020 alone,

Tragedies the CDC statistics have shown.

Twelve point two million considered suicide

And the forty-six thousand people who have died

One point two million tried to take their own life

How can we be so blind to so much inner strife?

This is an issue that I can't idly pass by

And if you knew my story you'd understand why

I've been in those same shoes; I've walked that story out

Those steps are agony and make you want to shout

Rage against the grief, the unfairness of it all

If only we were glad and didn't always fall

-Please do not take your life-

I've been lucky enough to have someone help me through

I hope beyond reason that we'd help others out too

Because this is an issue affecting millions out there

All it takes to start helping is for someone to care

To rise to the occasion and show others their worth

Through our kindness and care, a new movement we can birth
A world that cares deeply for all states of mental health
Listening to others, growing knowledge in its wealth

-Please do not take your life-

If you're reading this in a crisis of your own
Dear reader, please just know that you are not alone
Don't take your life because you feel forgotten there
Because even if it's just me, someone **will care**

You matter, you're worthy of some kindness and love.

There's hope for your future, learning to rise above

Notes: Statistics cited come from

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, National Center for Injury Prevention and Control. *Suicide Prevention*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2022
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Mental health services benefit your quality of life, yet they are often inaccessible and stigmatized. As a result, many people can go unnoticed or untreated, with chronic mental conditions affecting how they feel, think, or behave. Moreover, mental health is so critical to your well-being and survival that it can chemically imprint on your DNA, allowing psychological issues, such as traumas, to carry through generations. Such trauma(s) passed down through generations is known as generational trauma (also referred to as intergenerational trauma). Generational trauma occurs when years of unresolved mental issues are overlooked, creating an endless cycle of unhealthy cognitive behaviors and illness in one's family history.

As a daughter of Mexican parents who migrated to the United States, my family struggled through years of poverty and displacement before they arrived here. My father, in particular, was orphaned and raised by his great-grandmother. As a result, he often spent his childhood walking to school without shoes and offering to carry strangers' grocery bags for some change. Poverty can have a significant influence on one's mental state, leading to extreme levels of stress, depression, and anxiety. Yet, when you don't have the luxury of seeking mental health services, people are often left to live in a constant state of survival that involves suppressing their emotions and memories. Physical abuse was another factor that played into my parents' childhoods. In the Mexican culture, because mental health is stigmatized, parents often don't know how to regulate their frustration when parenting their children, so they turn to unhealthy disciplinary actions that involve corporal punishment.

This type of punishment was equally damaging and scarring to both my parents. When my parents arrived in the United States with nothing but the clothes on their backs in their young adulthoods, they faced language, financial, and cultural barriers that often left them displaced.

Now, how may this have impacted my life? My parents raised my siblings and me around the fears and traumas they faced throughout their childhoods and young adulthoods. When I decided early in my youth to seek mental health services, I realized I was diagnosed with high depression and anxiety and had difficulty communicating my emotions. Therapy helped me notice that all the issues that stemmed from my childhood came from how my parents raised me. For example, I realized my fear of finances stemmed from witnessing my parents struggle with money. However, one advantage I had that my parents and grandparents didn't have was the accessibility to resources like therapy and an education system emphasizing mental health and its importance. Specifically, I took a psychology class in high school and learned about generational trauma. In this course, I acknowledged how unresolved mental issues could affect your body and be carried down to your loved ones. It was eye-opening when I witnessed the effects of generational trauma throughout my family history. Now, I can educate my parents on mental health, and my siblings and I can break the cycle of these traumas.

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The Mental Struggle With My Body - By Belen Torres

Ever since I was about five years old, I can remember always being the “gordita,” meaning “chubby girl” in Spanish. I started ballet classes at that age, and I was soon removed by my mom and placed into a different type of dance class. Not too long after the switch, I heard my mom telling a friend of hers she had taken me out of ballet classes because in her opinion, I was too heavy for that genre of dance. Although I didn’t think much about it at the time, I now realize that experience, along with many others, had a major impact on my relationship with myself today.

All through elementary school and middle school, I was bullied for being fat. The most challenging school year was my 7th grade year. Jackie, a girl in my band class, who I never even had a full conversation with, would come up to me daily, to tell me how disgusting I was for being so fat. On one occasion, our school band was invited to join one of the high school bands during a football game. While the high school band was warming up, my friends and I were just having fun and dancing to the music. Jackie walked up to us and said, “Belen, you really should stop dancing, all I see is your fat hanging out everywhere.” Sadly, it was not just at school that I would be body-shamed.

My mom most likely felt she was being helpful with the comments she would constantly make; however, she unintentionally taught me, my worth was defined by my appearance. I would constantly be told not to wear certain clothing because I did not have the body type for it. On many occasions even more recently, she would say, “Since you and I don’t have nice bodies we cannot wear...” and would proceed to say whatever she had to say in that moment. Good or bad, my mom and the rest of my family have made several comments regarding my body. I was constantly compared to my sister and cousins who were all thin. When I was only eleven years old, I began taking weight loss pills and would try different ones since that time, all through high school. My four years of high school I was no longer chubby but I was still extremely insecure and constantly wondering how big or small I looked to others. A year after graduating high school, and exactly one month before my 19th birthday, I had my first born, a precious baby boy.

My body changed a lot after having my son and I had a hard time “snapping back” to my pre-pregnancy size. Not long after giving birth, my son’s dad and I met my family at the movie theater. The first thing my mom said to me when she saw me was, “I have told you so many times not to wear that shirt. It is very unflattering on you.” Any time my mom would make those types of hurtful comments and I got upset, her response was always, “I tell you these things for your own good.” Right before my son’s third birthday, his dad and I broke up and I started engaging in restrictive dieting and intense exercise for

over two hours, five to six days a week. I was determined to get my “revenge body”.

It had finally happened, I was the smallest size I had ever been, but the number on the scale just did not meet my expectations and that was my hyper fixation, the number. I guess it didn’t help that when I would get complimented for my transformation and would share that excitement with my mom, she would respond with, “Yes, you have lost lots of weight, and you could still lose more.” Oh how I lived for those compliments and the attention I would receive. Any time I knew a man found me attractive, I would feel like I was finally accomplishing something major in life. Even with all these compliments and attention however, I was still very insecure with myself and constantly worried about how I looked. I started restrictive dieting again and decided to hire a personal trainer.

Working out has always been a hobby for me. I genuinely enjoy working out and feeling my body getting stronger and building endurance. I went to the academy in Tucson, Az to become a correctional officer where I ended up receiving an award for the female top achiever in physical fitness. While working with my trainer, I learned so much and built a lot of muscle yet I was still unsatisfied with that number on the scale. I would take tons of pictures and compare them to old photos of me. I would zoom in on every picture and if I saw any kind of flaw I would tell myself I needed to work harder and lose more weight. At one point, I posted before and after photos and one particular post I now regret, was a comparison of my toned body at that time, and a picture of chubby nine year old me. The caption I had written said, “I hate the word fat, but who is the fat kid now?” I always considered myself to be someone who was against bullying and I would never make comments or jokes about anyone’s appearance, except for when it came to me of course. I would always say I did not want to get pregnant again for fear of gaining weight and not being able to lose it.

In 2019 I found out I was pregnant with my second child. During this time, COVID-19 had come and everything changed. The gym having to close was a bit saddening but I was not about to let that get in the way of my fitness goals. Every morning before work I would go to a nearby park to run and do some workouts with the equipment I had. I worked out my entire pregnancy expecting it to help me lose the baby weight faster. Friends and family would say that I was going to be back to my pre-pregnancy size in six months tops, with how much exercise I had been doing all nine months. In August of 2020, I gave birth to my precious baby girl.

Only three weeks postpartum, I was getting impatient with the way my body looked and frustrated that none of my clothes fit. I decided to go to the gym which caused me some complications so I had no choice but to wait for my checkup and approval

from my doctor to be able to workout again. Months went by, I was working out every morning and no matter how many hours of sleep I got, whether it was four hours or seven, I would get up and go. I became a stay at home mom and would wait to eat until my spouse got home. Before I knew it, I was heavier than I had ever been in my life. One day, I came across a post on Instagram regarding intuitive eating, intuitive exercise, and body positivity. I began following other influencers, dietitians, and trainers promoting that same mindset and lifestyle. I read books, would listen to audiobooks, and I would share on social media what I was learning, in hopes that others would find it helpful.

Intuitive eating and exercise is basically about learning to listen to your body and its hunger cues, along with learning how to let your body rest or take it easy during workouts. I would share several posts discussing this and the benefits of this lifestyle. Some of the things the posts said were along the lines of allowing yourself unconditional permission to eat the foods you want and enjoy in order for it to lose its power over you in a sense, so eventually you no longer feel out of control around those foods. Some other posts talked about weight loss not being truly beneficial and I started to build a narrow mindset around weight loss. I wanted everyone to agree with me and no longer feel the need to lose weight. Although I never argued or said anything to anyone directly, I would get so upset when people shared before and after photos thinking of it as a bad thing and feeling like they did not listen to what I shared. I began telling myself I still wanted to workout but did not desire to lose weight or shrink my body. Deep down I knew I was lying to myself but I thought if I just continued telling myself the same thing repeatedly, I would eventually truly feel that way. There was so much criticism within the body positivity community when singer Adele and actress Rebel Wilson had major body transformations. So many got angry at them for losing weight and getting thinner, as if they were responsible for our insecurities and healing. This is a community that constantly preaches no one owes an explanation for their weight gain. That is when I began questioning what it is I was really advocating for. If I want to influence others to be body positive, shouldn't that mean everyone should be allowed to do what they wish with their bodies without having to explain themselves? If no one owes an explanation for their weight gain, shouldn't that apply for those who lose weight as well? I began to realize, I went from one tunnel vision to another and I needed to find a balance for myself.

Friends would reach out to me and tell me how much they appreciated my posts. A lot of them would share with me some of their experiences with body dissatisfaction, or body dysmorphia and some would even open up to me about eating disorders they struggled with. It is important to point out the stigma with eating disorders. A close friend of mine struggled

with an eating disorder known as, bulimia nervosa. Unfortunately, because of his larger body size and simply for being a male, he would get invalidated by the people he reached out to for help. Thankfully my friend was able to overcome his struggle with the eating disorder itself, but the body insecurities are still a struggle for him. Even though I was reading, learning, and sharing all about body positivity, I still felt like I did not recognize the person I saw when I looked in the mirror. There were so many days that I would just cry because I would see old photos of myself where I was much smaller, yet I never saw myself that way in that time. I could not stand the way I looked. I knew I did not want my kids to feel the way I did so I decided to seek help and started seeing a psychologist as well as a psychiatrist.

I was diagnosed with depression, anxiety, ADHD (Attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder), and was prescribed medications for all three. The medication has definitely helped me however, I don't think I could have gotten as far as I have without my counselor. Through my therapy sessions I have learned, my entire life I was seeking approval from others, especially approval from my mom. I always considered myself as someone who isn't a bully, someone who does not judge or make fun of others for the way that they look, I never realized I was in fact being a bully all this time. I was so hateful and mean to myself. I spoke to myself in ways I would never speak to anyone, especially not the people I love and care about. I have learned that it's great to have health and fitness goals, but I am so much more than my body. I have learned that there is a middle ground, if people do not wish to change their bodies that is perfectly okay and up to them, but I am not a hypocrite or a bad person for wanting to lose weight and change the way my body looks. I cannot say I never struggle with my self confidence anymore because I still do. It has been years and years of me struggling to accept myself, feeling so much shame I avoid socializing, miss out on making memories with my loved ones, and avoid going to the doctor for fear of judgment. I go to doctor's appointments and because of my BMI (Body Mass Index), they tell me all my problems can be solved through weight loss. They do not believe me when I say I strive to live a balanced lifestyle. Because of my struggles through all these years, it will take lots of work but it is not impossible and it will get easier as I continue to work on it. I recently started consultations with a RDN (Registered Dietician Nutritionist), who is amazing and has taught me slow weight loss is much more sustainable and healthy than fast weight loss and it does not have to be a miserable journey of restriction.

My RDN has advised me to add certain habits into my daily life that will help me but also reminds me at every appointment, not to hyperfixate on anything. Stress can really play a role in weight and obsessing over numbers and trying to be perfect every single day can be counterproductive. Rest is extremely

important so I have really been prioritizing sleep, rest days from the gym, and just working on balancing everything out without beating myself up on the days when things don't go as planned. I have learned all foods can be a part of a balanced diet and I do not have to restrict myself from anything to make progress. In just the short time I have been working on all of this, I already feel and see a difference. People still make comments that trigger me at times but I remind myself that we have been raised to think our bodies have to look a certain way and to moralize food. I remind myself of these things because there will always be people who disagree with me and no one is responsible for my healing but me. It is up to me to learn to love myself and break that cycle for my kids. It is up to me to stop living for approval of my size from others and learn to work toward my own goals and be happy with myself regardless of what others think or say.

I hope my story can bring awareness and help anyone facing similar struggles. I hope anyone who recently gave birth can enjoy their precious baby instead of giving into the pressures of "getting their body back". I hope we can all just let others exist in whatever size they are and know that it is okay to want to lose weight and set goals to look a certain way but it is also okay if people do not have a desire to change and are comfortable as they are. Bodies come in many different shapes and sizes. The health and fitness world is full of people in bodies of different shapes and sizes, we just do not see very much body diversity on those types of ads. "I chose to be fit, I did not choose to be obese" (Anonymous). Remember, you are so much more than your appearance or a number on the scale.

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To self,

I love you. It may feel like you are alone or that no one wants you around, but I am here with you always. I see what you do to cope with tough times, and I am proud of you. We all need reminders that we are doing well, and I am here to tell you just that.

Mental health is something that many people struggle from. Although it is not ideal, it is okay. I am here with you now to let you know that these hard times are only for a little while longer. You will get the life you desire and deserve. Your hardships will not go unrecognized. Only when we get to the root of your triggers, then we can decide how best to resolve them. I say “we” to remind you that I am here with you.

You are continuously doing the inner work. When you read about self-care, it should feel personal for you. I do not think your mental health triggers were created overnight, so as you process your feelings of forgiveness to those who may have hurt you in the past just remind yourself that once you let go it will get easier. Once you let go, you can move forward.

Healing takes time, but time heals all wounds. It is easier said than done. My heart is always open for you. You are meant to be a source of love and compassion. You already know that there is either love or the absence of love. Love is the only emotion. When you love yourself, you trust yourself. You trust yourself enough to say to yourself that you will not put yourself through what you do not have to. You have choices.

Happiness is a choice, and I am proud when you choose to base your happiness off your blessings. I know most of your anxiety stems from control. It is freeing when you focus on the positivity in your life and what you can control. You are on the right path. I know you know this because I send you signs. Listen to your intuition and I promise to speak to you softly. I am here to give you all the reassurance you need. Remember that you are light, you are love. Everything you need is within you.

I promise you.

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What is mental health? Is it waking up every day optimistic for the day ahead? Or is it crying yourself to sleep at night because you get overwhelmed with your own emotions? Well ladies and gentlemen it is actually both of them. It is the pretty and the ugly that we experience throughout our lifetime. Without the ugly we can't appreciate the pretty, but sometimes the ugly tends to stay a lot longer than we hope for. That is when our brains tend to play tricks on us and life doesn't seem as great as it used to be.

When I got into high school, the topic of mental health was a huge one. You would hear students around you joke about "You're always quiet, you must be depressed." Or "Stop being sad, you're going to end up kill yourself." I didn't find any of these jokes funny since a friend of mine committed suicide just two years into high school. It's sad how people don't realize the internal battles that everyone must fight just to make it through the day.

It all started when I was a little girl. I never understood why I was so angry all the time or why I felt this deep, lonely feeling in my chest. It was constant arguing and disappointment when no one, not even my own family, would understand what was going on with me. That was something I found quite ironic since I was told later on that my father had suffered the same feelings throughout his life and how depression can be hereditary as well. That just added to my anger because how could they not understand? It was literally in front of their face all along! It was honestly something I thought everyone felt and that those nasty feelings would pass, until I got older and noticed everyone around me grew out of that "phase" and I didn't. It was many, many, MANY years of confusion until I finally got an idea of what was going on with me. Things started to make sense a little, but it still didn't give me the answer I wanted. What was that ugly feeling in my chest and why didn't it go away?

That ugly feeling happened to be called depression and the fact that it didn't go away was my anxiety. In my culture, those two things are seen as a sign of weakness and it is always about "just thinking more positively". Little do they know it is much more

than that. That is when I realized why my father never spoke up about his mental health growing up. I feel like I would've been able to get help sooner if he talked about it to someone. Nonetheless, It wasn't until I reached my breaking point that my parents actually paid attention to what was going on with me and finally decided to take my mental health seriously. I could not believe that it took me talking about suicide for someone I love to notice something was going on.

We looked into many different psychologists and psychiatrists until we found one that was the perfect one for me. Someone that listened and didn't just want to shove pills down my throat before figuring out the issue. If you're looking into getting help for yourself or someone you love, most ways to be able to find someone is by calling your insurance and asking them for a list of providers. You can also talk to your primary doctor to see your different options and what kind of therapist is best for you. There are also websites like "betterhelp.com" or "psychologytoday.com" that can help you out with that as well. Luckily there are many different options for you to explore now than there was before.

Every year 850,000 people die from suicide due to severe depression. If mental health was taken more seriously and talked about more, then maybe people wouldn't be so afraid to speak out on the topic. There are many therapists that are willing to help at a very low cost or no cost at all. My advice for everyone going through it is to not give up. Even though it may seem like a long road ahead, there is always light at the end of the tunnel and when you least expect it, you'll be feeling like yourself again. I'm still on the road to a better mentality but like everything, you have your good and bad days. The secret is to never lose faith and to always believe in yourself, even when others don't. If my blog helps at least one person out, that is already taking a foot in the right direction.

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